


**IN A CLASS OF THEIR OWN** Students at a signal school in Thane

MANDAR DEODHAR

# A Signal Achievement

***Happiness delivery:** A school that operates under a flyover at a busy junction provides underprivileged street children education, three square meals a day, and also trains them in life skills*

**SIGNAL SHALA**
**FOUNDED: 2016**
Thane, Maharashtra

*By* **DHAVAL KULKARNI**

I am yet to make up my mind, but I want to become a policeman," says Kiran Chandrakant Kale, a Class 10 student, as portraits of Mahatma Gandhi and former president A.P.J. Abdul Kalam stare at him benignly from the walls of his classroom. Kale is not just another student spelling out his career goal. He is among the underprivileged street children being educated at a 'signal shala', a school located under a flyover at the busy Teen Haat Naka in Thane.

The students in this unique school belong to migrant families from de-notified tribes. They once sold flowers and trinkets or even begged at the traffic signal. Out of the educational mainstream, they ran the risk of being sucked into a vortex of substance abuse and crime.

The school, which now operates from a set of five air-conditioned containers, was launched in June 2016 by the NGO Samarth Bharat Vyaspith. Children here get an education, three square meals a day, and also training in life skills. "I used to sell flowers at the signal," says Kale. "Initially, when the teachers approached my parents, they refused to send me to school. They felt that education would not help us in any way. But the teachers eventually prevailed on my parents, and I came here." Kale and his sister stay with their mother and maternal